

Q What happens to my amazing body during pregnancy?

Over the course of the nine months of your pregnancy, your body has to adapt and make space for your growing baby, to ensure your baby's growth and protection, and to prepare itself to give birth. Some of the changes you go through will be obvious—a growing abdomen and larger breasts, for example—but many will seem imperceptible to you, or you'll notice them only when they have a domino effect that makes you wonder what's going on. Here's an overview of all the amazing things your body is doing to adapt to pregnancy and nourish your baby.

NOSE

From early in your pregnancy you may notice that you have a heightened sense of smell. This may be due to more blood pumping round your body. However, some people believe it could be a protective mechanism—to keep you away from substances that could be harmful.

LUNGS

Your lungs move up and back as your pregnancy progresses. They are being pushed to their uppermost limits, which can make you breathless. Your air intake increases to help to supply you and your baby with enough oxygen.

DIAPHRAGM

The increasing size of your uterus during pregnancy means that your diaphragm—the flat wall of muscle that controls your breathing and lies beneath your lungs—is pushed upward, squashing your lungs in the process, but increasing your capacity for breathing deeply.

STOMACH

Your stomach may send signals to your brain for certain foods that you “must” have (cravings) and to avoid foods that make you feel sick (aversions). Some scientists believe that cravings encourage you to fill a nutritional gap, while aversions stop you from consuming substances that could be harmful to your pregnancy.

INTESTINE

Increases in progesterone during pregnancy inhibit the action that moves food along your digestive tract. Although this can cause constipation and heartburn, the slowing down means you can get the maximum nutritional benefit from food as it passes through you.

Did you know?

Before you are pregnant, your uterus is roughly the size of a plum. By the time you have reached six weeks, although you may not feel pregnant, your uterus will have grown to the size of an apple. During your whole pregnancy, your uterus will expand to become between 500 and 1,000 times its normal size.



BEFORE PREGNANCY

SIX WEEKS

CERVIX

During your pregnancy it remains strong, and tight. In labor, following hormonal changes triggered by the pressure of your baby's head, the cervix thins and widens. The cervix lets go of its “plug” and when it is fully dilated your baby is ready to be born.

UTERUS

The lining of your uterus—the endometrium—thickens to receive the embryo, and its muscular wall grows to accommodate the baby and to give you the strength to push the baby out when the time comes. Once you reach your third trimester, your uterus will start to produce “practice” contractions, known as Braxton Hicks. No one is sure why we have these, but it's assumed it's to prepare the uterus for the job it has to do during birth.

